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Charles McPherson
Part II

Part 2 was conducted via Zoom on September 9, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

CM: Have you got it? I guess I should try and push that.

MR: I'm good, I think you're probably —

CM: There's a little thing for me to poke. I don't need to do it?

MR: I don't think so, but — if you've got something telling you —

CM: It looks like I'm supposed to say "Got it".
Okay just a minute.

MR: Yeah, you can say got it, or okay.
All right guys.

MR: All right. Thank you very much.

CM: Okay.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius — I'm going to start again.

CM: Yeah don't talk when he's talking. Okay? Lee Ann? Okay go ahead.

MR: All right. My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to be speaking with Charles McPherson after 26-some years before — our first interview. Thank you for joining me.

CM: Well thank you, thank you for having me.

MR: You know the first time around we got to shake hands, now we're sort of zooming hands.

CM: Yup.

MR: This is a sort of a tough question but you've been involved in jazz for a long time. We spoke about your time with Charles Mingus and having your own bands all these years. And then you just spoke about playing a jazz festival like three weeks ago in Upstate New York. Can you think about the biggest changes you've noticed in jazz and the business of jazz between that time back in the sixties and now?

CM: Well yeah, that's — I think there — you know I think there might be more genres of jazz maybe now than before. In the sixties you had the influence of Charlie Mingus, people like John Coltrane, the avante garde was happening you know, Ornette was there. You had you know Art Blakey and of course Thelonious Monk, Max Roach, you had these great musicians that were still here and everybody had their own style but I think now the difference is there just might be more different offshoots of jazz. Or people that play or record companies that promote and they'll use the term jazz you know, and there are just more variations I would say. Maybe a little more variations. In terms of the aesthetic of it,

I mean the actual quality and level of musicianship and artistry, you know the sixties and even before that had very high levels of musicianship and artistry you know. That didn't start with the sixties, that's always been around. And now you — I'll tell you what is different, academia is different. There are more schools — high schools, colleges — that have jazz programs. That wasn't quite like that in the sixties and of course earlier. So that's different, so therefore it's producing younger players, you know there's a lot of young people that are enamored of jazz, some kind of jazz, and it's in the schools and so it's more available in a way, at least by way of academia. And so that's a little different, and it produces, you know, a slew of young players that are being, you know that are getting out of schools, that are starting careers. So there might be, maybe more people playing jazz and yeah — so things have changed but to answer your question the best way I can I would say that there's more genres now maybe, and a lot more players you know.

MR: Interesting you say that because on my way home last night I had an NPR show on and they were playing this music and I couldn't quite place it but then the person came on and they were doing a show about Indian music — music from India — and its effect on jazz and how some people embrace that. So you're correct, there's Celtic influences, in fact bands sometimes like to promote themselves as embracing world music so you have jazz and all these other influences coming in. When you mention about the number of players coming into the music, have you had people come to you, young players seeking advice about how to make a living in jazz?

CM: Oh yeah, I do. I am, you know a lot of young players will call me up and talk, which I like, I like that. And they will ask for advice — musical advice — more often than not that kind of advice or saxophone advice. And then now and then business advice. And I will, you know, I will tell them the little I know and give them the best advice I can. And you know that's a hard — I'm much better at giving musical advice or saxophone advice. Business advice, I need some advice myself on that. I've done things my way, I've gone my way, my particular way, and so each player of these young people, it's very important to figure out what demographic they want to cater to in terms of the public, and these are the things I tell them about. You know jazz is — we talked earlier — is a pretty under the name of so-called jazz is a pretty big umbrella you know, and a variety of style and musical behavior by people and groups that will say "jazz." So okay, so be it. So with that in mind I will tell — I give the advice to young people since it is that way then figure out who do you want to reach you know? Because there's an audience for all of these different nuances and these different genres. There's a straight-ahead bebop audience, or neo-bebop that leans towards that. I'm a member of that club. There are people that are more into more popular forms that have jazz as part of their DNA and then you have

rock, you have rhythm & blues, you have funk, you know you have all of these different takes on jazz music. And you've got people from all over the world that are playing that are bringing nuances of their culture to the music and amalgamating it with some of the part of the DNA of what I would say jazz is. So you have all that. So there's a big audience and who do you want to reach. And then think about that deeply, because whatever — you want to do something that makes you happy, you want to do something that you do need to take care of yourself, you need shelter, you need — you know you've got to pay your rent, you've got to live and it takes money to live. Think about just the basic mundane problems of trying to play art in this society and music in particular, and jazz is really a pretty difficult sell. So you have to think about that and then think about what kind of music are you able to be honest about and play, and then think about the business aspect. I definitely tell them to learn all of the new ways that music is being used these days. So you've got all the digital, all of that, and then you know you've got cell phone, you've got streaming, you've got — there's millions of dollars being made with music and so I will tell them to understand every aspect of the music business, not just playing in some bar you know, "I Got Rhythm" in some club, or "Countdown" in some joint, which is fine, I love that, but think about the ways that music generates money, and make sure that you get paid. Because there's a lot of people that really make a lot of money off of music and by way of music and music is being played by people. Make sure that you get your just due. So that means you have to have some business awareness and understanding, and you've got to take part of your consciousness and your energy and really kind of look at these things. Now I will say this: a lot of the young players of today are a lot more on that page than I was as a younger person in my early twenties. You know I didn't really think deeply about money, business, or anything. I just really wanted to learn how to play, and really play really well you know play as fast as possible.

MR: Yeah you take me back to you had told a story about hearing Charlie Parker play "Tico Tico" and that it made sense to you.

CM: Well yeah.

MR: That was so interesting that it just made sense to you. And you said, "I knew immediately that this is what I wanted to do."

CM: Yes. Right. That's true. Yeah. And I think a lot of people felt that when they first heard Charlie Parker. I'm not the only one. But when I first heard Bird, yeah, that was overwhelming because it made perfect sense to me. And there was something about the way — because he played a lot of notes, but a lot of people played a lot of notes but I could hear the linear logic with Charlie Parker. I could tell — and I couldn't — I would never use terms like that — "linear logic" or — I wouldn't use that term. I wouldn't even know what that was when I'm 15, 14 years old. But I could understand it, let's put it that

way. It made sense to me. And so that was what got me. It was compelling. And I got it. I couldn't say what it was, I couldn't use the right verbiage or the right semantics to describe — I knew nothing about harmony or theory or any of that. I did know major scales. I could play the major scales but I didn't know anything about the cycle of fifths or any of that you know. But I could tell that he connected these long sentences and they were like perfectly, seamlessly connected. And then the logic of it was apparent to me, and that's what got me.

MR: I have a quote here I want to read from the late Jimmy Heath. It says, "I think Charles McPherson is the number one saxophonist who has incorporated the Charlie Parker language. He has this quality of eruption in his lines, he has that Charlie Parker language and he's still himself. He's so far inside of the part nobody else gets, that you would have to say it's amazing."

CM: Oh well I didn't know he said that, that is really a nice compliment.

MR: It is indeed.

CM: Yeah that is a very nice — in fact yeah, that's a nice one.

MR: I think I'll send that to you.

CM: Thank you, Jimmy, thank you.

MR: Put it on your resume.

CM: Yeah, that is beautiful. I mean it's self-serving that I say that, but coming from a great musician like him, and a wonderful, wonderful saxophonist and wonderful composer, that was around during the really golden age. You know his age really was privy to all of the great musicians before Charlie Parker. These people were still around and still living, and he's heard these people in person. It's not abstract for his — what was he born, 19 what 29 or 28? I don't know somewhere probably 1926, 27, whatever it is. But that age of those people, that generation, were privy to all these great saxophone players, trumpets, big bands, you know just all — everybody was still living pretty much. So he's a great musician and his playing and his writing reflects his natural talent but it also reflects all of this great music that he absorbed. So that's — a compliment from him is very special.

MR: You were indicating finding your audience for young musicians and reaching them. I want you to see if you can name this tune. Are you ready?

CM: Yeah.

MR: It starts with a rest. [scats]

CM: Okay. Well I know what it is already but go ahead. I think it's mine — I think it's an intro.

MR: It is indeed.

CM: to a tune I wrote for my last CD and last record project, and it's entitled "Dynamic Duo."

MR: "Dynamic Duo."

CM: Yeah. And it features David Wong, bassist and Jeb Patton, pianist. And both of whom were with my group.

MR: I want to ask you about the, not just the writing of it but the arrangement. Way back in '98 when we spoke you said, "The writing process is the loneliest, most miserable thing."

CM: Oh for me — I'm sure it is not with everybody but, yeah.

MR: But beyond the initial tune I found that the arrangement of it was compelling because you had that very memorable little lick and then it went into this unison piano and bass complex, followed by a bass solo, and it wasn't until over like 3-1/2 minutes that we heard anything as far as a sax or trumpet solo.

CM: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: Was this a conscious decision to —

CM: Yeah. It was. Yeah. Because most of the time you're going to get the trumpet or the saxophone or the horns play first. So just for the sake of variation and, you know, to add a different flavor, you know I like to have the bass or piano player play first, not only in clubs but on records as well. And it was written to be their feature you know. It was written to be their feature. And it was basically inspired by my involvement with Paul Chambers, Barry Harris, Billy Higgins, and Lonnie Hillyer, a trumpet player, and myself. We had a gig and you know the great Barry Harris and also Paul Chambers both Detroit people, and of course I'm from Detroit and Lonnie Hillyer, the trumpet player was from Detroit as well. So Billy Higgins who is I think from California or Texas or something like that. But that was the rhythm section of a gig many years ago, in the late sixties. And so I was kind of inspired by the way Paul Chambers and Barry Harris played with each other. So fast forward to now, when we decided to do a record, a live record date with Smoke Records in New York, I wanted — that CD and record project is dedicated, it's a tribute to Barry Harris, a great pianist and my mentor as a kid. And so I really wanted to just my tipping of the hat to Paul Chambers and Barry Harris. Because during that gig these two people, and Billy Higgins, I mean these people were really playing really well with each — really good with each other you know. And it was inspiring to hear that. And I just said let me write something for this great bass player of today, which is David Wong, and great young pianist Jeb Patton, and just write a really interesting tune, or figure for bass and piano.

MR: Indeed. And I'm picturing you, were you sitting at the piano laboriously writing out this [scats]-type line?

CM: Yeah.

MR: Is that how you did it?

CM: Yeah. Basically yeah. I actually basically it's really kind of like a solo I would do. And of course I have a way of — what would you say — framing it a certain way so that there

are certain nuances being adhered to that will make it not just a solo but a tune, and there's a way that you can — I use the term "box it" or conceptualize certain phrasing and melodic nuance and a way that you maybe recapitulate to some degree here or there that makes it not just a rambling solo but actually a little tune. And so I've tried to do the best I could trying to do that. Yeah.

MR: You did good.

CM: Yeah.

MR: I bet they were happy to see it. I'm just picturing —

CM: No they weren't that happy. I don't know if they were happy to see it because they had to really — they had to — I mean it's pretty notey, you know there's a lot of notes there and so, and it's in unison and the rhythm is kind of tricky a little bit. It's just based on "I Got Rhythm" but you know the line is not real easy. Now I've seen other people look at that and not want to deal with it so — yeah but these two guys are so talented, David Wong and Jeb Patton, that they — I mean for them it's a challenge and they ate it up. They nailed it for sure.

MR: They did. It sounds perfect.

CM: Yeah.

MR: And I just want to compliment you on the idea of the formatting of it, even up to the end where it's sort of a surprise ending.

CM: Um hum. Yeah.

MR: [scats]

CM: Yeah. Abrupt. Yeah.

MR: Excellent.

CM: Thank you.

MR: You mentioned of course Barry Harris, and I just did a review on this book with Pepper Adams.

CM: Yes.

MR: And you are quoted a number of times. I wanted to read one thing here I found fascinating.

CM: Okay.

MR: When you got together with this group of young men around Barry and you said, "'Man these people are really different.' Harris was a taskmaster and at one point asked McPherson to show him his high school report card. He had a C average and Harris was unimpressed. 'Oh you're an average kind of guy,' the pianist said. It won't work because this music is complicated and you're not going to be able to play it if you're a C kind of guy.'"

CM: Yeah. That's true.

MR: "This is not a skinny bubble here."

CM: Yeah, yup, no that's true. That change — that made an impression on me. I never had thought of it like that and when he said that I under — it made it me understand because I'm learning how to play this music and I'm understanding and seeing the complexity of it. I'm learning that oh, this is some higher math here. This is not arithmetic. This is trigonometry. So I could tell that yeah — and then when he made that statement and equated it to music and the complexity of the music, then I knew that I'm going to have to deal with — dealing with complexity no matter where it's coming from or what the medium is, is going to be something to deal with. And so I immediately knew that there is a level of — what would you say — deliberate yeah, a level of really deliberate effort to try to do anything at a certain level whether it's getting a better report card or playing music or playing basketball — it didn't make any difference. It's a level of seriousness and dedication that you're going to have to actually be willing to invest. And I might as well — I mean really what Barry was saying and I understand — I kind of understood it then — that this kind of excellence you have this kind of attitude about it no matter what you're doing and so when you're starting, when you're playing music then that same level of willing to invest is still there so it's not like — you use this for everything including music. So get accustomed to pushing yourself, no matter what it is. And then I don't care if it's getting your schoolwork, homework, understanding something in class, be willing to invest your mind toward making that better or nailing it, completely understanding it and doing it at a high level and just building your chops in that way will make anything you do the same, because it's all the same, really. And what makes it all the same is you're the one behaving at a certain point in time with whatever the situation is, and so just get yourself to having a high level of attainment no matter what it is, so when you get ready to play then your chops are there because you're already thinking that way. I understood what he meant you know.

MR: Yeah. I was involved in an aesthetic education program for some years and you're making me think of how we used to connect the different art forms and that observing an abstract painting or watching a dance performance — especially a modern dance performance — and being able to make some cognitive sense about it applies certainly to your playing as well.

CM: Yeah I think it applies to everything. So what I mean by that is — I was reading something about Beethoven, like a kind of biographical thing. And he made a statement that was curious. And he said, "If you know the secret of correspondence you can do anything." And I think I understood what that meant, and that's kind of what Barry meant. And I see what it means now. And basically when you say looking at dance, looking at art, if you're able to look at anything and see how it corresponds to any other

thing, no matter what the construct is, no matter what the medium through which a particular behavior is being — it doesn't make any difference. You see the — you see the correspondence between the two supposedly different constructs. But the behavior — you can see it. So then you become — you understand the DNA of metaphor and the DNA of analogy — analogists. You can see the thing. And the only difference is the mediums through which particular things are being expressed, but it's still being expressed by human behavior and everything that's dealing with that. So it applies to anything. So I can look at a basketball player, say like a guy like Michael Jordan for instance, and him going down the basketball court, and the way he pivots and zigzags I can make that be accents, rhythmic accents. Instead of a drumstick on a drum doing an accent, it's a human body doing an accent. So an accent, if you see the correspondence and you're able to see that, then you start seeing the bigger picture of things and the little minutiae starts making sense because you see the macro and the micro starts making sense. Because you already are looking at the bigger picture. And the micro and the macro are the same. The only difference is the viewpoint. So, and then if you can look at the bigger picture, that gives birth to metaphor. That gives birth to the secret of correspondence, that gives birth to that, so that makes probably anything you do, whether it's playing a horn, whether it's playing golf, it doesn't make any difference what the medium — it's like if you can understand that then that's like an epiphany in a way. There's a dimension of mind and conscious cognitive awareness that happens right there you know.

MR: Marvelous. I wonder if you've ever had a circumstance where you were the elder musician with wisdom and, much like Barry Harris, and you tried to pass that on to younger musicians who might have been on a very narrow path?

CM: Yeah, well I do, I mean because I teach so I don't teach it in a school, but I teach privately. And I teach, you know kids and, adults as well. And that is one of the things that I kind of learned about teaching is like the art of — you've got the craft of teaching and then you have the art of teaching. And really to me art is the higher level of what craft is. Because yeah, but anyway to make a long story short, I think this is when you start having a bunch of students you start developing — first of all you have to be a wordsmith of some sort because you've got people, some of these people are young and their attention span is what it is. You've got to be able to nail maybe difficult abstract thought with ten words or less in order to cause the epiphany. To cause the door to open. To cause the Aha! moments, and you don't have much time quite often. So you will develop metaphor, you start developing/using analogy, and all of this that we were talking about is being able to explain abstract thought to someone who knows less and have the door open. And that, a lot of times you have to have the Will Rogers approach, it's this really simple language, knowing how to use metaphor, ten words or less to cause

the door to open. The Aha! moment for the student. And that becomes like I think that's a part of the DNA of a teacher. Because it's not like you're just dispensing data and information, you've got to do it in a way that it's being absorbed and then that's where you have to — there's a little four dimensional chess being played there because you've got to understand how the mind works, how the subconscious mind, the conscious mind — you kind of have to understand the difference between craft, between art. And you've got to be able to nail it and you've got to use words that's understandable and then so therefore this is what I mean. You have to be a little bit of a wordsmith.

MR: Well I watched an Aha! moment, one of your lessons with a saxophone player is on a video, and I just got a kick out of this because he played something and then you said something that's so basic that most people wouldn't bother. And you told him to put both his feet on the floor.

CM: Yeah.

MR: Like —

CM: What was he playing? Was he playing saxophone?

MR: Playing a tenor.

CM: Okay.

MR: And he had one of the iRealPro things on the screen I think. But I think he was sitting but your point was you're not rooted to the ground here.

CM: Yeah, right, yeah.

MR: You know and it's a very basic thing and I was pleased to hear you just point that out and the look on his face was like oh, okay.

CM: Yeah, yeah, yeah. Well yeah, so there again there's — for me there's a reason for that and it had nothing to do with how it looks. It's got something to do with — because there's a lot of unconscious — oh what would you say — a lot of unconscious things going on with how you — what you do with your body. Your body language. And then you know it's not just that but it's also just basic physics you know. Your feet on the ground on an unconscious level, your two feet flat and in a certain position is telling a part of your mind to be in a state of readiness. Okay so that means it's a different level of alert, of being alert. The other thing, just the physics of it, you have the earth under your feet and for your feet to be a certain way it's the security of it. There's a security there of it, and a state of readiness. And all that. So you've got the psychological minutiae involved with that. And then you've got just basic physics. You've got better leverage. So and I always use this as an example in terms of state of readiness. If you look at two great tennis players just before they start to volley, look at how their feet are and then look at what they're doing. They're actually moving left and right with both feet because they're getting in a state of readiness for the ball to be over in this corner, the corner to

the right, and anywhere on the court. Because the guy, the person, is going to hit the ball anywhere. So his state of readiness is not for him to stand up with his feet any kind of way. It's ready to volley, which means the ball might do anything. Well when you're playing and you're improvising in the stream of time, that same state of readiness psychologically, physically, and what that does mentally in terms of subconsciously making you be in a state of readiness is what kind of state you need to be in when you're improvising. Because you're taking time, space, and — rhythm, time, and space, twelve tones at least in the Western scale, and you're behaving in an improvisational way in real time. That — you've got — it's a state of readiness on a high level of alertness on all levels — left brain, right brain, consciously, physically. So there you go. So it's a way of — so that's what I meant by that. Now I'm not going to say all of that to a student, it's too many words. But I'm just saying that behind it is not just the empty being concerned about visuals. I'm thinking about leverage, I'm thinking about state of readiness, which occurs here. I'm thinking about the whole body, mind-body. So I'm thinking about the psychology of it on all levels. And that's because the one thing that I do do for myself is when I think — I will think in as many dimensions as possible. I'll try to look at any particular whatever, as many different ways as possible. And that's still subjective, because it's still me looking. And it's my concept of dimension and all that. So it's in the world of subjectivity. But I will give it a — what would you call it — a conscious effort to look at it more than one angle. And this is where I will, when I do that, even if I don't cover everything at least I'm using my will — volition — to know that maybe I should. And I will, I'll try you know.

MR: Let me ask you about —

CM: Now this is that part — I'm talking about the cognitive, deliberate analytical aspect up here. So I always make a point of really sort of segmenting the activity of who we are here, because we've got all these different ways of taking information and parsing it a certain way. So I'm aware of that also, and then I'll use terms and words to — I'll use it to what I want to do, and what I want to explain, and how I want to explain it to them and to myself.

MR: Is there a difference in your thinking process if you're playing on a tune like "So What" you've got two chords that last fairly long,

CM: Yeah.

MR: or if you're playing on something like "Giant Steps." Is there a difference that's going on up here?

CM: Oh yeah. There's a difference. Let's see, now see this is complicated because one tune has got two chords, another tune has a million chords. So here again is the psychology stuff. There's a certain — when you're dealing with harmonic movement that's only two

beats — so the harmony is moving at a quick pace. It's not there for four bars, eight bars. But it's moving every two bars. And the tempo is at a good clip. So there is a way that you have to look at all of that harmonic minutiae and there's a way that you have to look at a broader arc over that, which means you really do have to have your ears on and think melodically at the same time that you're adhering to time and space. So here again you're really walking and chewing gum at the same time. And see here's where all of this perception and how you're looking at things come in. Now everybody's different and there's a lot of ways to look at music. You can look at music rhythmically only, harmonically only, or melodically only. But the real deal is amalgamating all of that into one homogeneous behavior and then so therefore having the output be whatever it is. But see there again lies this different — different ways to think. And everybody's different. Yeah. So this is what Barry meant by you can't be a C student with some of this stuff here. You know? This is some stuff you've got to deal with. Now having said that there's also this part of the equation. The subconscious mind, who we are as human beings and people. Already here is every note that we've — we've heard every note it is. Because this big piece of meat is the greatest computer in the world. There's only twelve notes. We've heard every one of them since we came out of — since we pop out of the womb. We've heard them. Okay we've heard rhythms, we've heard chords — whether we know what to think about them, how to think of them, it's already there. So a lot of times success is based on what part of the mind, or what kind of mentation should I put in play to get the best results, and therein goes the four dimensional chess again and how people think you know, and you've got the variety of personality and then I can only say how I approach it. I'm sure other people approach it another way. But see yet again, I'll look at all of that and realize say a tune like "Countdown" where the harmony is moving very quickly, but I will still — part of my way of thinking is what are some of the common notes with all of that harmonic movement. Because they can be moving quickly and changing quickly but there are certain common notes that's connecting all of them or at least some of them. So your melodic ear has to be on. And see your cognitive mind, your analytical mind has to understand the form and structure of what's actually going on. But how you artistically behave is a whole 'nother game. That's another part of the mind. The analytical part will just say oh, you know it's "Countdown" so it's going up a minor third and then it's going to the fourth and then another minor third. You can get into all of that technical stuff and musical harmony and theory and all that. But how do you behave with that. Spend time — with time and space in real time and be creative. And that's really something. But the way I look at things, I try to look for what I call as best as possible a "unified field theory." Kind of what Einstein was looking for, a "unified field theory." What is the equation that really kind of nails the whole shebang? And maybe there's no

such thing, maybe there is. But I always try to look at what is the one thing that I can maybe — the form of mentation that might give me the best results. Is there one thing, of all of the many things and ways to think of things, what is the one thing that will amalgamate all these moving parts and all these brain departments and functionality. And then for me it's rhythm. Rhythm. Phrasing. That's for me. And my melodic ear is on. It's on, I have it on. There are certain things that I would say is static. They're always on. These ears are always open. They're never off. They shouldn't be. They should be always on. And then the rest is like phrasing it and the rhythmic aspect, rhythmic configurations. How do you phrase what you hear? And see rhythm has almost the last thing to say about it because you can hear anything. You might be — people who have perfect pitch, they can identify what they're hearing. Say well this is A, this is D or this is a A minor or this is a G seventh. They can tell you that without even thinking about it because they've got perfect pitch, whatever that means. They can tell you that. But how do you behave with that? How do you phrase that? There is a whole different thing right there, see? So this is like — what is the one thing that I could bring all these different mental functionalities together so that I could behave in a way that I'm musically successful. And then for me I — for me it's almost like the phrasing and the rhythm. Because I can hear what's going on. Fine. But how do I phrase it? And what is the rhythmic configuration of what I'm hearing? I can play a whole note, I can play a half note, I can play sixteenth notes. I can play any configuration I want. But what am I? Or how am I going to slice this hearing into parts? And what's the boss? What's telling me what note when? What's telling me? So I have a way of looking at music like what, where, when. So I'll use language as a metaphor. What, where, when. What is whatever the note is. Whatever the chord is. Whatever the sound is. Is it a diminished? Is it half-diminished? Is it major? Is it this, is it that. When and where is how do you sequence and geographically distribute what into these smaller pieces. And when is the rhythmic, the time and space aspect. When. You know when, what, where. You know when, what, where. So it's all three in it. All three. Now which one is more important/less important? And guess what? They're all equally important. Because what is meaningless. Where you put what is meaningless. And everything is time and space, according to some point of reference. Everything.

MR: If the when is working well for you, does that help to — I'm going to use the word "justify" pitches that maybe you didn't mean to play but if rhythmically they fit into your phrasing, does that sort of —

CM: Well I think — here's what I think — I think there's something magic about concerning yourself with the phrasing and the rhythmic aspect. And what I mean by that I think once you start thinking that way there is something very compelling about that because you've trained your mind to actually think that way, and that has a way of setting up a part of

your mind for it to actually be freed up and I think you start playing the right notes. Yeah. Because there's something compelling and hypnotic about that. For me. I can see — there's a high tendency of the note being right because some kind of way because the phrase rhythmically is the right configuration for the moment. It is so much the truth that the truth of the note will be there with that, it's a package deal.

MR: I like that. It's a package deal.

CM: Yeah.

MR: Are there more right notes these days, in 2024, than there were back in the late sixties?

CM: You know I'm going to have to take a bathroom break right quick.

MR: Sure.

CM: Yup, 30 seconds.

MR: Okay.

MR: I think I was trying to talk about —

CM: Are there wrong notes? More wrong notes now?

MR: The harmonic language that's acceptable nowadays as opposed to what might have raised eyebrows decades ago.

CM: Well I mean you know, so you used the magic word "acceptable." That depends. Because it's the same — at least in Western music it's the same twelve tones. It's still the same twelve tones. But what you could do with them is a lot different than it was hundreds of years ago of course. So nothing has changed, the only thing that has changed is people doing what they want to do. So really when you say "wrong" note or "right" note, it's almost according to what? You know according to what? So if you say a system of harmony, twelve tones allows for so many notes to be wrong or right, depending on how you're framing these notes. You know what I mean? So there again, I mean, because if you just play chromatics for instance, that's all twelve notes. You know, now, and let's say we can, you know like, you know people who play Indian music like sitar or some of those instruments, they're playing semi-tones. They're all between — everybody doesn't have the same system that Europe has. There are scales that there are tones between the tones. And it's even American composers that have dealt with semi-tones and all this stuff. So it all exists. But just dealing with the twelve tones mathematically boy, that's so many combinations of things. And what makes it right or wrong depends on what else — compared to what note. A wrong note is wrong only if the rest of it has been set up a certain way, the rest of the notes set up a certain way in order to make that. And then you could say well it's just dissonant. There's no such thing as a wrong note. So I mean you can always get intellectual about it. It's just like this: if you take art for instance, and you take a person who has a canvas and takes a bucket of paint and just throws it on the canvas and then whatever happens happens. So you know people could sit down and say,

"Well that doesn't look like Rembrandt," or "It doesn't look like Monet," it looks like — and then another person says, "Yeah but look how this yellow drips down, it mixes with this red and I did it with no kind of egoic intent at all, I just did it in gravity and do it, and who said art isn't that? And what it looks like and whatever you think it is is what's still art. So you can get into all these banter, these intellectual arguments, but for me at this point, a wrong note, I don't know if there is such a thing as that. But I do know there is such a thing as right ones. If that makes any —

MR: Well I've struggled to find a better word than "wrong." And most people answer well what's your intent or what did you do to justify, and I just want to insert something about what you were talking about with the bucket of paint, that in 1998 you said to me, "Almost anything that human beings that alter God or nature can be art."

CM: Okay. Yeah.

MR: I like that.

CM: I didn't know that. That's pretty good. Yeah.

MR: I should send you the transcript of what you said back then because, like today, you're very quotable, Charles. So I want to wrap up just a little bit of talk, I rarely do this but —

CM: Okay.

MR: Talk about saxophones.

CM: Okay.

MR: Because when I saw the video from Smoke I thought your saxophone, your alto was quite experienced-looking.

CM: Oh that's true. It's an old Selmer.

MR: It was a beautiful thing. Can you just hold it up there?

CM: Now wait a minute because was it the record date because I played at Smokes twice, the record date it was on a Selmer VI and then I appeared at Smoke, maybe a year later, and it was a King Super 20.

MR: Well I'm not sure which horn it was.

CM: If I see the picture I'll know which one it was.

MR: Yes, but which one do you have with you now?

CM: I have the Selmer. Want me to play a couple of notes on it?

MR: Well I'd love to compare the —

CM: Oh okay, now let me see your horn, let me see your neck.

MR: This is a Buffet.

CM: Oh that's a Buffet?

MR: Yes. And —

CM: Wow.

MR: The reason I was doing this is because I noticed something in your horn, whichever it was, and that was you know for years people have looked at this horn and go, "Wow, that's old."

CM: Yeah. It's an old —

MR: Finally somebody said, "Oh what a nice patina." Patina. So that's the word I've latched on to, to make me feel good about my horn.

CM: Patina. Yeah. Well you know when I saw the neck I thought it was a Selmer Balance Action.

MR: Okay.

CM: Well yeah. But those — I did have a Buffet at one time but I had a newer one. Yours is older than mine and I bet money that the sound is beautiful on that.

MR: Yeah. I've had it since 1966.

CM: You want to play it for me?

MR: No not really.

CM: All right. Okay.

MR: Well this has been fascinating, Charles, you're a very deep thinker. And you can come up with better adjectives than I can.

CM: Oh I don't know about that.

MR: I feel you are. But you also, you know you said this about yourself, there's a great promo that's out about "Reverence," your latest recording, and one of the things you said about yourself, "I really like the language of bebop which allows for a broad range of expression, but I'm not a civilized bebopper, I'm a wild bebopper and I might go anywhere from that jumping off spot.

CM: Oh well yeah, yup, yup, yup. Yeah. I try, and I will if I hear it.

MR: What's up next for you?

CM: Well I'm traveling a lot. Let me see, I've got a record date that I'm going to do with Brian Lynch coming up in November. You know Brian Lynch, really wonderful trumpet player, a good friend. And let me see, I'll probably do Smoke again at some point next year. Oh and I got a boat — a jazz cruise coming up in January. And I'm working quite a bit, I'm in Los Angeles in a couple of weeks from now, so I've been traveling quite a bit you know. So it's been good. Since Covid kind of calmed down a bit I have been working a lot.

MR: Well I really appreciate your time today, once again, and I wish I could shake hands but we'll just you know —

CM: Okay. We'll do it. All right. Thank you. I had a good time.

MR: Good. And thank Lynn for me for her assistance here.

CM: Okay. And send the link or whatever you can.

MR: Definitely will. Safe travels to you.

CM: All right thank you so much. Good seeing you. Take care. Bye-bye.